

The Swan Children's Lullaby

The emerald isles of the Celts roll green and misty between a silver sea and soft grey skies, dotted with thatched roundhouses, ancient oak groves, and rings of humming standing stones. Mist drifts over still lochs, and across it, just out of sight, lies the Land of Youth where no one grows old. The isles are full of gentle wonders: a playful shapeshifting faerie, an old, bright salmon, a shy selkie of the loch, and four children long ago turned into singing swans. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is full of ideas, listens kindly, and keeps a promise. The grandest deeds are done with imagination and courage and a kind heart, and even a fearsome-seeming stranger, met with a friendly word, often turns out lonelier than it is unkind.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.



Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.

Before you begin

For as long as anyone in the village could remember, four white swans had sung a lullaby over the Misty Loch each dusk. Their song lifted the evening mist and turned the whole sky to rose and gold, and the village settled to sleep beneath it. But this evening the song faltered. It wavered, lost its way, and forgot its own tune halfway through. A heavy grey mist crept up off the water and settled over the loch and the rooftops, and no one could find the sunset behind it.

Old Maeve the Tale-Weaver called the two of you to her side by the warm hearth of the Roundhouse. "You have heads full of ideas and kind hearts," she said, "and that is worth more than a loud voice tonight. Will you go down to the loch and help the swan children remember their lullaby, so the mist lifts again?"

Into your hands she pressed three gifts: the little harp, worn smooth with playing, a sprig of oak for luck, and a honey oatcake wrapped in a leaf. "Remember," she said, "here we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being brave, kind, and full of ideas."



What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Imagination, Courage, or Kindness?

Stop 1 The Grey Mist

The path led you down to the loch, where the mist hung so thick and grey that the water had all but vanished. Somewhere out in that softness drifted the four swan children, but the mist had made them quiet and shy, and not a feather showed.



How will you find them without frightening them away? You might stand quite still and listen for the smallest ripple. You might call out, softly and kindly, so they know a friend has come. What do you try?

When you moved gently and spoke kindly, four pale shapes came gliding out of the mist towards you: four white swans with long necks and soft, sorrowful eyes. They had been waiting, it seemed, for someone with a kind face. They drew close and let you sit beside the water with them.

Stop 2 Remembering the Lullaby

The swan children longed to sing, but the lullaby had slipped away from them. The words had come loose and jumbled, and three small verses now drifted in the mist all out of order. Until the verses went back the right way, the song simply would not hold together.

A playful shape rustled in a nearby oak: Pook the Puca, the shapeshifting faerie, who loved a puzzle as much as a prank. He tipped you a wink and offered a small, sideways hint.



Can you help them piece the lullaby back together? Listen to each verse in turn. Think about which one begins the song and which one ends it. Talk it through together, and trust the picture the words paint.

When you set the three verses in their proper order, the swan children's eyes shone. "Yes, that is it," they breathed. "That is exactly how it goes." The shape of the song came back to them like a half-remembered dream.

Stop 3 Playing It Together

Now the swan children knew every word, and yet they hesitated. They were shy of their own voices, and the smallest swan was shyest of all. She opened her beak to begin, but no sound came, and she tucked her head beneath her wing, afraid to sing alone.



This was never a fight. How could you help her find her courage? You carry the little harp. You might play a slow, gentle tune to lead them in. You might tell the shyest swan that she is not alone, and sing along beside her so that no one has to begin by themselves. What do you do?

When you lifted the little harp and began to play, and your own voices joined the tune, the shyest swan slowly raised her head. A single sweet note slipped free, then another, growing braver with each breath. One by one the others joined her, until all four swan children were singing together, clear and strong and unafraid.

The Dusk Turns Rose

The lullaby rose over the Misty Loch the way it always had, and the heavy grey mist began to soften and to thin. Bit by bit it melted away, and in its place the dusk turned a deep and glowing rose, shot through with gold, until the whole loch held the sunset like a mirror.

On the green rise above, the Ring of Standing Stones hummed along, low and content, as it does whenever the swan children sing. The four swans glided in a slow circle, their song pouring out across the water. And high over the loch, Danu the Kind looked down on all of it and smiled.

You had done it, and you had done it together: with your courage, with your kindness, and above all with your bright ideas. Goodnight, heroes of the Emerald Isles. Sleep well.

The Swan Children's Lullaby: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a gentle tale: nobody is ever frightened for long, no one is hurt, and good ideas and kindness win every time.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Roundhouse.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Kindness** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: anything at all for the little harp, a leaf or twig for the sprig of oak, and a small cake or token for the honey oatcake. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**.

When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Imagination and Kindness together, say, or Courage and Imagination).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed.

Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. By the misty loch, no hero stands alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll

Twist of Fate

1	Pook the Puca pops up and gives you one free hint.
2	You find your courage again, and take back one energy star.
3	A soft breeze drifts off the loch, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Salmon of Wisdom blows a lucky bubble. All is well.
5	A sprig of oak for luck: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A burst of birdsong, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

There is no foe in this tale at all, only four shy swan children who have lost their song. The story is won not by beating anyone but by drawing near gently, helping the swan children remember their lullaby, and then playing the little harp so they find their voices again. The shyest swan finding her note is the heart of it; let that moment land. When the song returns, the mist lifts into rose and gold, the Ring of Standing Stones hums, and Danu the Kind smiles. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The Swan Children's Lullaby: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward imagination and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Grey Mist (Easy)

The challenge. A thick grey mist hides the four swan children on the loch. The players need to find them and draw near without frightening them away.

Intended solution. This is a Kindness and Observation moment. The good, kind move is to slow right down: stand still and listen for a ripple or a soft feathered sound, then call out gently and warmly so the swans know a friend has come. Loud or sudden approaches make the swans shrink back into the mist; a calm, kind one brings them gliding out.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have a single white feather drift to their feet, or let the smallest swan give a quiet call they can follow. Any gentle, kind approach works, and once the swans see a friendly face they come close on their own.

Stop 2: Remembering the Lullaby (Normal)

The challenge. The swan children have forgotten their lullaby. Three short verses are drifting in the mist all out of order, and the song will not work until the players put them back the right way.

The verses. Read them aloud in a jumbled order, then ask the children to sort them. Number them only for yourself.

1. *Soft falls the dusk on the silver loch, little ones, rest your weary wings.* 2. *Up lifts the mist, all rose and gold, and the ring of old grey stones still sings.* 3. *Sleep now, sleep, till the morning sun wakes the world with the song it brings.*

The ordering clue. Tell the children the lullaby travels through one whole night: it starts at dusk, rises through the dark, and ends at the morning sun. The words that name the time of day give the order away: **dusk** comes first, then the **mist lifting** in rose and gold, then **the morning sun** last. So the right order is verse 1, then verse 2, then verse 3.

Intended solution. This is a Memory and Vocabulary moment. The players listen for the time-of-day words (dusk, then the rising mist, then morning) and use them to set the verses in order, dusk to dawn. Asking **Pook the Puca** for his hint works just as well.

Fallback. If the children are stuck, have Pook the Puca hum the first line, or point out the words "dusk" and "morning" and ask which one comes earlier in a night. Getting there with help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: Playing It Together (Normal)

The challenge. The swan children know the words now but are too shy to sing, and the smallest swan is shyest of all. She cannot find her voice on her own.

Intended solution. This is a Social-emotional and Courage moment. The players lead the song rather than waiting for the swans: play the **little harp** to give them a tune to follow, sing along so no swan has to begin alone, and offer the shyest swan a kind word so she knows she is not on her own. When the players go first and stay beside her, she finds her note and the others follow.

Fallback. If the children freeze, or wait for the swans to start, have the shyest swan whisper, "Will you sing it with me?" The moment the players hum any tune at all and invite her in, her first small note slips free and all four swan children join the song.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser, and there never was a foe, only four shy swan children who had lost their song. When the lullaby returns, the grey mist lifts into rose and gold, the **Ring of Standing Stones** hums along, and **Danu the Kind** smiles down on the loch. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, kind, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.